

Fig. 4.1: Ujjayini’s ancient mounds with the Sipra river in the background

Before getting to that courtship, what seems of interest are the circumstances which brought the prince to Vidisha. This happened when Ashoka journeyed to administer Avanti in the heartland of India, travelling across the black soil of the Malwa region, ‘rough, and trampled by the feet of cattle’.[2]

Ashoka was dispatched to Avanti as viceroy by Bindusara. Unlike his brief Taxila sojourn, he is depicted as having spent some ten years at Avanti while headquartered at Ujjayini, the political and administrative centre of the province, a city described as the ‘Greenwich of India’ since the longitudinal prime meridian was reckoned by Hindu astronomers from this city.[3] If so, he would have arrived there roughly around 282 BCE, some ten years before his father Bindusara died. By the time Ashoka got there, it was an urban centre of respectable antiquity, having flourished along the Sipra